UNIT 7 WRITING YOUR CURRICULUM VITAE (CV)

Structure

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7.0 OBJECTIVES

In this unit you will learn about the importance of a Curriculum Vitae (CV) while applying for a job. You'll learn to write your first CV or update a current one to ensure that it meets international standards. You will learn how to organize information on your CV under the most commonly accepted headings.

The grammar section will take you through a revision of different tenses.

Finally, in the writing section you'll use the given template to write your own CV.

7.1 WARM UP

Imagine that you are the manager of a McDonald's outlet in Shanghai, China. You are looking for a young person to take orders at the customer counter. You have received many CVs in response to your job advertisement. Put a tick against the personal information necessary to select the right candidate:

Name

Sister's name

Date of birth

Breed of the pet dog

Favourite food

Contact address

E-mail

Passport number

7.2 READING COMPREHENSION: WHAT IS A CV?

Read the following passage on what a CV is and how it should be written.

Your curriculum vitae (CV) is your most important weapon when it comes to job hunting. With your CV or resume you will be able to promote yourself.

Prospective employers will often make a snap judgment as soon as they read it. Even the most qualified people on the planet can find themselves rejected if the resume fails to impress the interview board. So how can your CV catch the attention of an employer?

Avoid making it too fancy and complicated. You only have about five seconds to grab the attention - if it is too clever and unreadable it will go in the bin.

Don't try to make jokes and never criticize previous employers.

CV length

There are no set rules governing the length of your CV - this will be decided on your career history, education and achievements. If possible, try to keep it to one page, but if this looks too crowded then spread it out over two sheets. If you write more than this, the employer has too much to read.

Everyone has a different theory when it comes to CV design. Don't make your design very complicated, just make sure everything is clearly marked. Include your career progress, education and achievements prominently so your prospective employer doesn't have to search.

Remember to include

Career history

Skills and strengths

Awards and achievements

Contact details

Here is a basic format: Start off with your name, address and contact details clearly listed at the top of the page. Follow this with a profile of yourself which should include an outline of your skills, experience and immediate career goals.

After this you can put in your career history - in reverse chronological order over the past 10 years - with brief descriptions of your responsibilities and achievements. Then comes education, interests/personal details and references.

Stick to the truth always

Make sure your CV is printed on good quality A4 size paper and never attach extra documents, letters or certificates. You can take these along for the interview. Read and re-read your CV, and then ask a friend or family member to read it as well. Make sure there are no spelling errors or coffee stains as these will be fatal. It is important to be truthful. Never try to smudge dates and jobs to hide periods of unemployment. A basic check will expose your deceit and ruin any chance of getting the job.

Follow all instructions on the job advertisement. If they want four copies of your CV, then you should send four. It is also important to get it in on time. Once again, remember your CV is the **first impression** that an employer has of you.

Activity 1

1) Read the passage carefully to answer the following questions:

i) How does a CV help in job hunting?

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ii) Why is it important to keep your CV simple and readable?

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iii) How long should your CV be?

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iv) In which section will you include your career goals?

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v) What do you need to keep in mind while describing your career history?

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vi) How can a friend help by reading your CV?

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vii) Should you hide that you were unemployed for six months?

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7.3 VOCABULARY: SUB-HEADS IN A CV

Although a CV can be organized in many different ways, most prospective employers would expect to see the following headings.

Education	Referees	Personal Details	Profile
Additional Skills	Interests	Professional Experience	

Activity 2

Peter Devereaux, a French graduate, is compiling his CV. He has collected the relevant details. Now he has to organise them. Look at the following points and decide which heading Peter should put them under.

For example:

University of Paris – Bachelor's degree in Business Management: answer = 'Education'

Writing Your Curriculum Vitae

i) Fluent in English
   - Interests
   - Additional skills
   - Education

ii) Pop music and dancing
   - Interests
   - Additional skills
   - Personal details

iii) Prof. D W Martin, University of Paris

- Personal details
- Profile
- Referees

iv) Able to work well in a team
- Profile
- Personal details
- Interests

v) Responsible for supply chain management
- Additional skills
- Interests
- Professional experience

vi) McDonald's chain – Assistant Project manager (2017 – 2018)
- Personal details
- Interests
- Professional experience

vii) Computer literate
- Interests
- Professional experience
- Additional skills

viii) Date of birth – 4 May, 1993
- Personal details
- Profile
- Professional experience

7.4 LISTENING: A CONSULTANT DESCRIBES A GOOD CV

Activity 3

Listen to this advice from a recruitment consultant on how to produce a good CV. Then, look at the following statements and decide which are true and which are false, according to the audio. You may listen to the audio more than once.

i) Employers don't care what CVs look like. (True / False)

ii) Companies only receive a few applications for each position. (True / False)

iii) Your CV should include as much information as possible. (True / False)

iv) You should spread your points out on the page. (True / False)

v) It is better to focus on key facts. (True / False)

vi) The most important features are that it is easy to read and looks good. (True / False)

vii) A good CV will guarantee a good job. (True / False)

7.5 GRAMMAR: REVISING TENSES

In this course you've learnt about the various tenses in the English language to denote the time of an action. Let us go through the following table to revise the most common tenses in English:

Tense	Use	Examples
Simple Present	• action in the present • habitual action • facts • talking about the future.	I go. I brush my teeth every morning. Oil floats on water. The President leaves tomorrow morning.
Present Progressive	• action taking place in the moment of speaking	He is playing. I am not playing.
Simple Past	• action took place in the past, mostly connected with an expression of time	I worked hard yesterday. He went home today morning.
Past Progressive	• action **going on** at a certain time in the past • actions taking place at the same time	I was working… She was going…
Present Perfect Simple	• action started in the past and continues up to the present	I've worked… She has not gone…
Present Perfect Progressive	• putting emphasis on the **course or duration** (not the result) • action that recently stopped or is still going on	He has been speaking since… I've been working for…
Past Perfect Simple	• action taking place before a certain time in the past	She had spoken…
Past Perfect Progressive	• action taking place before a certain time in the past	He had been painting…

Activity 4

1) Here is Jaishree Dutta describing her profile and interests in her CV. Fill in the blanks with the correct tenses. Use the table given above for reference.

Profile

I _____ (is) keen to follow a career in Tourism or Hotel Management. I _____ (is) well-organised, highly motivated and _____ (has) excellent communication skills. In addition, I _____ (is) reliable, flexible and quick to learn.

Interests

I _____ (enjoy) yoga, swimming, skiing and classical music. Last summer, I also _____ (participate) in the New York marathon.

2) This is Li Ming Cho describing her professional experience on her first CV. Fill in the blanks with the correct tenses. Use the table given above for reference.

Professional experience

I _____ (study) commerce in Australia for three years.

While graduating, I _____ (do) voluntary work at the college library. My job _____ (is) to enter student profiles into the college database.

Recently, I _____ (manage) the cash counter at the local super-market. This _____ (give) me additional skills in managing customers and dealing with money.

7.6 WRITING: WRITING YOUR OWN CV

Using all the information you've gathered on writing CVs in this unit, write a good CV for yourself. Keep in mind the ideal job that you're looking for. Before you actually start writing, organize the points under the various headings of a good CV.

If you are writing a CV for the first time, include any work experience that you have. This could be unpaid, voluntary, summer job(s), internship or extracurricular activity.

You can use the following template to write your CV. Feel free to make changes to the template according to your needs.

Curriculum Vitae

_____

_____

_____

_____

Tel: _____

Email: _____

Profile	
Education	
Professional experience	
Additional skills	
Interests	
References	

7.7 LET US SUM UP

In this unit we focussed on the importance of writing a good CV. You learnt that clarity and impact are necessary to make your CV stand out in the crowd. In the listening section, you heard advice from a job consultant on the most important aspects of a CV. You learnt about the main headings for organising information on your CV.

The section on writing enabled you to use a popular template for writing a CV. In the grammar section you revised tenses.

7.8 ANSWERS

Activity 1

i) A CV helps in job hunting by giving a first overall impression of one's achievements to the prospective employers.

ii) If a CV is not clear and readable it will get rejected. Most employers spend only 5 seconds on a CV.

iii) A CV should not be more than one or two pages. We must choose the information that will go into the CV.

iv) I will include my career goals in my profile.

v) My career history should be in reverse chronological order. This is because an employer will be most interested in my latest job.

vi) By reading through my CV, a friend can help me make sure that I've made no mistakes.

vii) No, one should not lie in the CV. Most employers will check on the basic details. A lie will ruin all chances of getting the job.

Activity 2

i) Additional skills

ii) Interests

iii) Referees

iv) Profile

v) Professional experience

vi) Professional experience

vii) Additional skills

viii) Personal details

Tape Script

With CVs, first impressions are everything. For some vacancies, employers receive an enormous number of applications. So it's important that your CV stands out from the rest. Firstly, it should look good – well-presented, with a clear layout, with lots of white space so that the information can be located easily. Secondly, you should choose your points carefully so that your CV is concise and relevant. Keep it to one page, if you can. Use the spell-check on your computer. Use appropriate phrases, perhaps from the job advertisement, to express your achievements and abilities. To sum up, the key words are – clarity and impact. A good CV can go a long way in getting you that all important job interview.

Activity 3

i) False - *The consultant says CVs should look good.*

ii) False - *The consultant says - For some vacancies, employers receive an enormous number of (a lot of) applications.*

iii) False – *You should select information carefully.*

iv) True - It should have a clear layout and lots of white space.

v) True - *Your CV should be 'concise' and 'relevant' - only put in information which you think is important for the job.*

vi) True - *Clarity and impact are very important.*

vii) False - *It won't guarantee a good job, but it could help you get an interview.*

Activity 4

i) Jaishree Dutta
am, am, have, am, enjoy, participated

ii) Li Ming Cho
studied, did, was, have been managing, has given